







Flying High

AFTER WINNING BIG AT SUNDANCE, **SHAUNAK SEN'S** *ALL THAT BREATHES* IS GETTING A SPECIAL CANNES SCREENING

In 2018, Shaunak Sen was in Cambridge for a brief fellowship. Speaking about Delhi with his friend and faculty member Maan Barua one day, Sen, a filmmaker, envisioned the city—grey, hazy, monotone skies, filled with noxious air. "It was this feeling I was interested in," says Sen. His thoughts eventually morphed into his second film, *All That Breathes*. The documentary has been one of India's most successful exports this year. Having won the World Documentary Grand Jury Prize at the 2022 Sundance Film Festival, it has now also been selected for a special screening at Cannes 2022 (May 17-28).

After discovering Saud and Nadeem, two Delhi-based brothers who had devoted their lives to protecting Black Kites, Sen began filming them in early 2019. Trying to craft a hybrid visual language that is both designed and spontaneous, Sen recounts how he found an equilibrium: "The first month of the documentary is not about shooting, but the labour you put into getting your subjects' trust. When you initially bring cameras, it's obtrusive, very rarely do we find something 'usable' in this period."

Having used hand-held cameras to make his first film, *Cities of Sleep* (2015), Sen knew *All That Breathes* would be more controlled and aesthetic. "If you ask someone to say something, it's never going to work. So, for instance, there's a moment when Saud talks directly to the camera. I briefed him—'The camera will pan towards you, and only after, should you say what you have to'. I call this 'treated actuality'."

While Sen's film has been lauded for its cinematography (Riju Das, Ben Bernhard and Saumyananda Sahi have all been credited), its treatment of sound is also interesting. "That's probably the work of Niladri (Shekhar Roy). He meticulously recorded everything from the brothers to non-human creatures. We wanted a texture that would make you feel like you are inside the room with them," says Sen.

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Last year, Rahul Jain's documentary *Invisible Demons* played at Cannes. Although *All That Breathes* shares with it an ecological conscience, Sen says he's cautious about the environmental discourse these days: "It's either bleeding-heart sentimentality, or extreme cynicism bordering on bleakness. The brothers have a wry resilience, like they've got a front-row seat to the apocalypse where birds are literally falling from the sky. Yet they go about their work with quiet grace."

Sen says while he's terrified about going to Bombay to pursue a career in fiction, he has found non-fiction to be more hospitable. "The dissemination infrastructure is still sparse but seeing *An Insignificant Man* and *Katiyabaaz*, I have guarded optimism about the future of non-fiction in India." ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee